

Woodburn suspends Flock Safety license plate cameras amid concerns of federal ICE enforcement

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The city of Woodburn has suspended its use of Flock Safety surveillance cameras in town. (Courtesy of Flock Safety)

The city of Woodburn has suspended its use of the Flock Safety Camera System.

After multiple Woodburn residents raised concerns about the role surveillance cameras could play in aiding federal immigration arrests during the Nov. 10 council meeting, the city decided to pause its use of the system for at least two months.

“The City of Woodburn is committed to keeping our community safe while respecting the concerns of our community members,” Mayor Frank Lonergan said. “Based on community input, pausing the Flock camera system is a prudent step.”

Flock Safety manufactures and operates automated license plate readers and video surveillance systems and holds contracts with numerous cities across Oregon and the United States. In December 2024, [Woodburn contracted with the company to install 24 cameras](https://woodburnindependent.com/2024/12/10/woodburn-city-council-inks-contract-to-install-license-plate-reader-cameras-in-town/) (<https://woodburnindependent.com/2024/12/10/woodburn-city-council-inks-contract-to-install-license-plate-reader-cameras-in-town/>), throughout town with license plate recognition software to capture vehicle make, color and license plate information.

According to the city, cameras don't have facial recognition power, and law enforcement uses them to help solve thefts and violent crimes, rather than traffic enforcement.

Woodburn residents' concerns over cameras

The city's decision to suspend Flock Safety followed an extensive public comment session where residents raised concerns about the camera's data being used by federal agencies to target and gather information on Woodburn's immigrant population.

"While these cameras are often promoted as tools for public safety, they pose a serious risk for immigrant and working class communities," one resident said. "The data they collect can be accessed by outside agencies, creating fear and distrust among residents who already live under constant surveillance."

The city has stated that Woodburn's Flock Safety system parameters have been set to allow access only to the Woodburn Police Department and other Oregon law enforcement agencies. The city has also said it will conduct a "comprehensive review" of the Flock system during the pause in use.

Under Oregon sanctuary laws, both the city of Woodburn and the Woodburn Police Department cannot participate in immigration enforcement. Oregon law also explicitly states that law enforcement agencies cannot use agency money, equipment or personnel to detect or apprehend people for immigration enforcement.

"Our goal is to ensure that the system is used responsibly, that the information collected remains secure, and that it is not accessible to any agency outside of Oregon," Woodburn City Manager Scott Derickson said.

City, police say data is safe from outside authorities

According to the city's Flock Safety transparency page, the camera's data is retained for 30 days. The page also states that the data is owned by the Woodburn Police Department and cannot be sold to third parties or used for immigration enforcement, intimidation or harassment based solely on a protected class such as race.

Information gathered by the Flock cameras has been searched 108 times in the last 30 days, including 17 related to thefts or shiplifting, 11 for hit-and-runs and 10 related to warrants, according to an online Flock data dashboard.

Despite the city saying only state authorities can access the cameras, multiple residents called for an independent audit to determine how Woodburn's Flock Safety data is used, who has access to it and whether any agreements exist with federal or private entities.

"Flock cameras are being used by the Woodburn Police Department to identify criminal activity and solve criminal cases. However, the risk these tools have on our community outweighs the benefit," another resident said. "We demand an audit of the use of the flock cameras. And then the audit must include the number of requests made by other agencies, FBI, ICE, (U.S. Drug Enforcement Administration) and other federal agencies."

In the city's statement, Woodburn Police Chief Jason Millican said that in the short time Woodburn has used the Flock Safety license plate reader system, it has helped solve violent crimes and vehicle theft cases.

Nevertheless, the city has said it will continue to prioritize public safety while upholding its residents' civil liberties.

"Our police have never worked with ICE agents," Lonergan said. "They will not work with any ICE agents."

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